

Early Armored Cars

The first armored vehicles to see action in World War I were used by the British and Belgians around Antwerp in 1914. They engaged the German forces as they advanced and acted as rescuers for pilots forced down behind enemy lines. These early cars often had improvised armor and weapons, but specially designed vehicles were soon in service. The stalemate on the Western Front limited the use of armored cars, but they still had value in theaters where the fighting remained mobile.

▷ Lanchester Armored Car

Date 1915 **Country** UK

Weight 5.4 tons (4.9 tonnes)

Engine Lanchester 6-cylinder gasoline, 60 hp

Main armament .303 Vickers machine gun

The Lanchester began its career with the Royal Naval Air Service. A total of 36 were built, first seeing action in Belgium, where they harassed German forces and rescued downed pilots. In 1916, they were sent to Russia, from where detachments traveled as far as Persia and Turkey.

▷ Minerva Armored Car

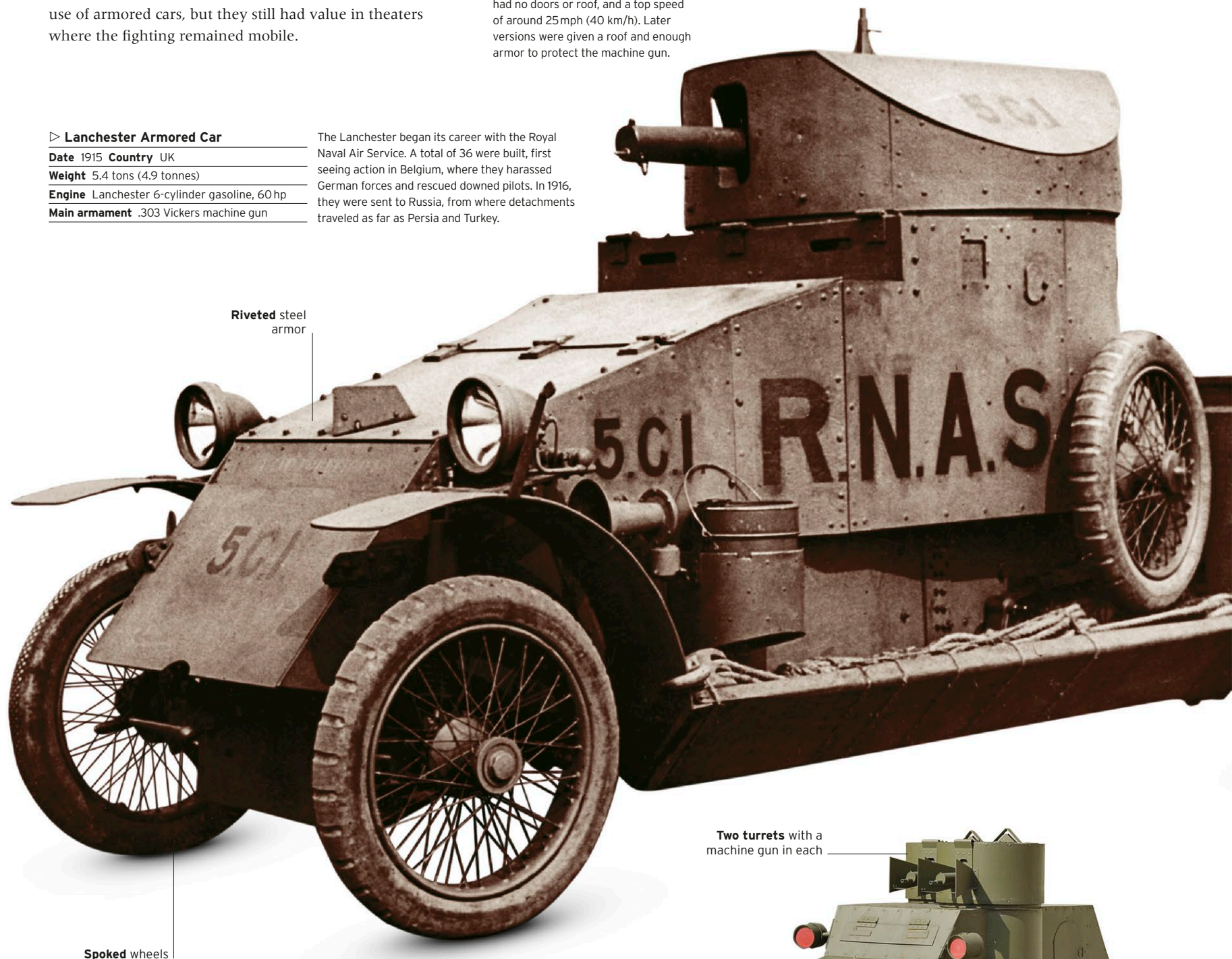
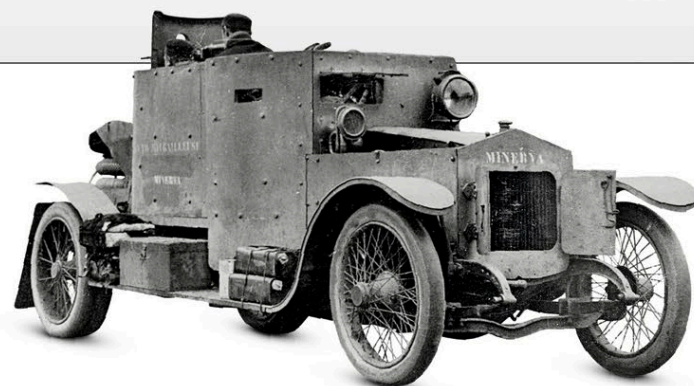
Date 1914 **Country** Belgium

Weight 4.5 tons (4.1 tonnes)

Engine Minerva 4-cylinder gasoline, 40 hp

Main armament 1 x 8 mm Hotchkiss machine gun

The Belgian Army ordered some 30 armored cars from the Belgian car manufacturer Minerva. The first model had no doors or roof, and a top speed of around 25 mph (40 km/h). Later versions were given a roof and enough armor to protect the machine gun.



Two turrets with a machine gun in each

50 hp engine

▷ Austin Armored Car

Date 1914 **Country** UK

Weight 4.6 tons (4.2 tonnes)

Engine Austin gasoline, 50 hp

Main armament 2 x .303 Hotchkiss Mark I machine guns

Although the Russian Army was enthusiastic about armored cars, Russia lacked the industrial capacity to build them, forcing it to look overseas. This vehicle was built by the British Austin Company, and Britain subsequently adopted it in 1918. Several Russian versions were captured and used by the new Eastern European nations after the war.

